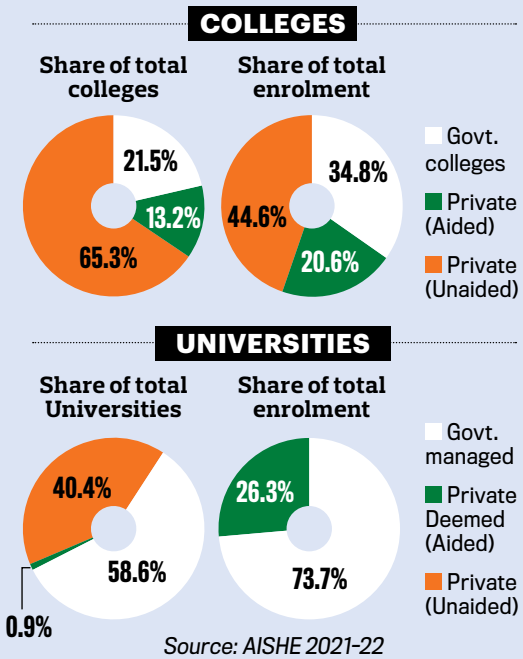
EDUCATION

ent Ratio, emphasise research and increase skilling

THE HIGHER EDUCATION UNIVERSE

Of 48.3 million students, 78.9% are enrolled in undergraduate level courses and 12.1% are enrolled in postgraduate courses



Source: AISHE 2021-22

EDUCATION IN 2047

Accounting for India's demographic bulge

300-350 million*
Students in schools, from 265 mn currently

100-120 mn**
Students in higher education, from 43 mn presently

2-2.2 mn*
Schools required, from nearly 1.5 mn currently

80,000-100,000**
Colleges required, from 40,000+ at present

2,000-2,500**
Universities required, from 1,000+ right now

**Because of declining birth rate, demand for higher grades will rise, but primary grade enrolments might stabilise or decline, to achieve a pupil-teacher ratio of 15:1 in primary grades and 20:1 in higher grades **For about 60 per cent GER by 2047*

If these statistics highlight a substantial gap in educational access, the quality of learning outcomes is even more alarming. The National Achievement Survey (NAS) by the ministry of education revealed that only 45 per cent of fifth-grade students could read at a second-grade level. Similarly, the 2023 Annual Status of Education Report (ASER) found that one-fourth of rural students aged 14-18 could not fluently read a second-grade level text in their regional language.

In higher education, despite the expanding ecosystem, few institutions achieve respectable positions in global rankings. While universities in the US and UK dominate, Chinese institutions are rapidly climbing the ranks. This disparity is unsurprising, given India's lag in research output, exacerbated by the country's meagre investment of less than 1 per cent of GDP in research and development (R&D) within higher education. In contrast, the US allocates nearly 3 per cent of its GDP to R&D, and China invests over 2 per cent, significantly boosting its global research output and innovation. Although there has been an uptick in research publications from India, their impact and citation indices remain low.

The scenario is equally troubling in skill training, where a mere 4 per cent of India's workforce receives vocational education. This is in stark contrast to China's 24 per cent, and the over 75 per cent seen in Germany and Switzerland. Moreover, the employability rate of Indian graduates is approximately 48.7 per cent, suggesting that over half of the graduates lack the skills necessary for the job market.

ENTER THE NEP

We have the world's largest population aged between 10 and 24 years. Reviving education and skill development is absolutely critical to reap this demographic dividend and capitalise on opportunities in a knowledge economy. It was to accomplish exactly this goal that the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 was drafted.

The NEP proposes a comprehensive overhaul of the Indian educational framework, replacing the 10+2 structure with a 5+3+3+4 model that aligns educational stages with developmental stages—Foundational (ages 3-8), Preparatory (ages 8-11), Middle (11-14), and Secondary (14-18). It emphasises experiential learning and critical thinking, reducing curriculum content to core essentials to foster in-depth un-

INDIA HAS THE HIGHEST NUMBER OF STEM GRADUATES WORLDWIDE. IMPRESSIVELY, OVER 40 PER CENT OF THEM ARE FEMALE. THIS HAS TO BE LEVERAGED BY GIVING THEM ADEQUATE SKILLS TRAINING